

Chapter 27 Part 1

The sound of running water drowned out their conversation.

The group of people from the office quickly left after washing their hands, ending their brief gossip session.

But Liang Shi never came out.

She frowned as she quickly browsed through all the information online related to Chen Liuying and Bai Weiwei.

The official information released was scarce, and netizens' revelations were all filled with "maybe" and "probably," with very few accurate descriptions.

Online discussions about this incident had already exploded.

[My friend saw Bai Weiwei at the entrance of Huayue International the day before yesterday. She was walking with a group of executives, and her expression was so fawning she might as well have been shining their shoes.]

[Going to Huayue International doesn't necessarily mean she was drinking with clients, right? Huayue International is a legitimate place.]

[If it wasn't for drinking with clients, why would she jump off a building? She must have been xx'd.]

[Do you have evidence? Don't make things up without proof.]

[We happened to pass by Huayue International around 10 PM the day before yesterday and saw a very beautiful Alpha carrying Bai Weiwei out. At that time, Bai Weiwei looked like... well, like it was afterwards.]

[Then how do you know it wasn't that beautiful Alpha who did it with her? Why insist that she was drinking with clients to get resources?]

[Exactly! Ridiculous! Our Liuying doesn't need her to do these things, okay? Her drama bookings are already scheduled until the year after next!]

[Ugh! Who doesn't know Chen Liuying is just a marketing fraud? Don't try to muddy the waters upstairs.]

[With that green-screen acting skills of hers, what a waste of that face.]

[...]

The online flame war intensified, while Chen Liuying's studio had yet to make any response.

Two hours had passed since this incident broke out, already missing the optimal PR timing.

Bai Weiwei's suicide attempt was probably beyond their expectations, leaving the studio in chaos with no one able to respond promptly.

Meanwhile, photos had also surfaced online.

The most widely circulated and credible ones were of Bai Weiwei entering Huayue International with a group of executives, and of Zhao Xuning carrying her out of Huayue International.

Someone just happened to capture them.

The latter photo was very blurry.

But everyone online said it was a very beautiful Alpha, so people believed it.

After all, from the photo, you could see the Alpha had a great figure.

After exiting Weibo, Liang Shi called Zhao Xuning, but her phone was turned off.

"..."

Helplessly, she could only go to the hospital.

//

The hospital entrance was surrounded by crowds.

Reporters from major media outlets had already rushed over after hearing the news, holding cameras¹ and waiting in the hospital, while security personnel continuously maintained order, but couldn't make them all leave.

Everyone was working hard to get first-hand information.

Because of Bai Weiwei alone, the hospital's order was disrupted. Ten minutes later, a hospital official came out and said: "Bai Weiwei has been transferred to a private hospital. Please leave, reporters."

Initially, people didn't believe it. Many reporters held up microphones asking, "Is Bai Weiwei still alive?"

"How serious are Bai Weiwei's injuries? What are her chances of survival?"

"What is Chen Liuying's attitude about this? Is she at the hospital accompanying Bai Weiwei?"

One sharp question after another made the hospital official lose patience. When microphones were thrust directly at his mouth, he pushed them away and said coldly: "Sorry, these are all patient privacy matters. Please leave the hospital, reporters. Don't disturb the hospital's normal operations. If you haven't evacuated within five minutes, we will take forceful measures to remove you."

He left after speaking.

The crowd of reporters looked at each other in confusion.

Although they were unwilling to believe it, Bai Weiwei had indeed been transferred.

But they had no choice but to stop disrupting public order and went outside to stake out.

When Liang Shi entered, she wanted to find Bai Weiwei but discovered no one would help her.

The name "Bai Weiwei" had become taboo in the hospital.

She couldn't contact Zhao Xuning either, otherwise she could have asked Zhao Xuning to take her upstairs.

However, she found a workaround and asked the nurses' station, "Did Dr. Zhao Xuning come in today? I need to see her about something."

"Sorry, Dr. Zhao doesn't have a shift today," the nurse said. "If you need medical attention, please go to the payment counter to register. Thank you."

Liang Shi: "..."

She was rebuffed.

She then went upstairs to Zhao Xuning's office, but found it locked. A Beta nurse passing by recognized her and greeted her, "Ms. Liang, are you looking for Dr. Zhao?"

Liang Shi nodded, "Do you know where she is?"

The little nurse shook her head, "Our hospital doesn't allow us to say. You should contact her yourself. Dr. Zhao won't be coming to work today."

"Do you know about Bai Weiwei..." Before she could finish, the little nurse frantically shook her head, "I don't know, please don't ask."

She ran away after speaking.

This incident had caused quite a stir online, especially since it involved a human life.

Particularly with Chen Liuying bearing the title of "Internet's Number One Imperial Alpha²," she had exploded overnight after just entering the entertainment industry, creating resource conflicts with many people.

Now that something had happened to her, many were waiting to watch her downfall. Some competitors had already started buying internet trolls to steer public opinion. Negative keywords about Chen Liuying kept trending on hot searches, climbing higher and higher in rankings.

The hashtag #Chen Liuying Manager Jumping Off Building# remained at the top with consistently high engagement, steadily occupying first place with a deep red "exploding" character following it.

Liang Shi wanted to confirm Bai Weiwei's condition, but due to the special circumstances, she could only return empty-handed.

However, as she was going downstairs, she received a call from an unknown number.

She originally wanted to hang up, fearing it might be some unsavory person again.

But considering Bai Weiwei's situation, she answered, "Hello?"

"This is Zhao Xuning." The other party said directly, "This is my personal number."

Hearing this, Liang Shi immediately asked: "How is Bai Weiwei? What happened that night? Why did she suddenly jump off the building?"

Ten minutes wasn't enough time to do anything.

Moreover, from what she knew of Bai Weiwei, she didn't seem like someone with a fragile heart.

"She just got out of life-threatening danger," Zhao Xuning's voice sounded exhausted. "She wasn't violated that night."

"Then..." Liang Shi paused, "Why did she jump off the building?"

"She fought with her girlfriend," Zhao Xuning was also helpless. "She jumped when her emotions got too intense."

Liang Shi: "..."

Isn't her girlfriend you?

Liang Shi's words got stuck in her throat and didn't come out.

So it was a misunderstanding.

"The specific details are too complicated," Zhao Xuning said. "I can't explain it clearly in a phone call. I just called Xu Qingzhu but she didn't answer. When she asks about it later, please explain for me."

Liang Shi readily agreed, "Okay."

"It's better not to let her see the online comments," Zhao Xuning instructed. "She's not suitable for intense emotional fluctuations right now."

"Mm." Liang Shi also gave instructions in return, "By the way, Xu Qingzhu blacks out when she drinks too much and doesn't remember anything from that night, so it's better not to bring it up if possible. Let's just turn the page on this matter."

"Okay."

Everything had been said, and they could have hung up.

But for a moment, neither hung up, and instead they both sighed simultaneously.

"I'll get back to work," Zhao Xuning said. "Take good care of Xu Qingzhu."

"I know. If you have new information, tell me too. If Xu Qingzhu finds out about this, she'll definitely want to visit Bai Weiwei. When she wakes up or when visitors are allowed, please let me know. Thank you, sorry for the trouble." Liang Shi said politely.

"Okay."

After responding, Zhao Xuning suddenly said teasingly: "You sound much more pleasant now when you speak."

Liang Shi: "..."

She had always spoken pleasantly.

It was the original owner who was unpleasant!

However, she didn't chat much more with Zhao Xuning. She still had to go back to work at the company. Knowing that Bai Weiwei was safe put her mind at ease.

After hanging up, she drove back to the company.

Footnotes:

1. **长/槍短炮 (cháng qiāng duǎn pào)** - Literally "long guns and short cannons," this is a Chinese idiom referring to cameras with long and short lenses, commonly used to describe photographers and reporters with their equipment.
2. **禦A (yù A)** - "Imperial Alpha" - In Chinese ABO (Alpha/Beta/Omega) fiction, this refers to a dominant, powerful Alpha character. The "禦" (imperial) suggests someone with commanding presence and authority.

Chapter 27-2

//

The magazine department was still in chaos.

When Liang Shi went out, it was lunch break time, but at 2:00 PM there would be afternoon clock-in to continue work.

Obviously, she was overtime.

When she went to the entrance to clock in, it already showed 35 minutes overtime.

The overtime electronic announcement broadcasted in the office area, and a group of people turned their heads to look in unison.

Somewhat embarrassing.

Liang Shi immediately returned to her workstation. The little girl from this morning was still sitting there reading.

After she came in the morning, everyone in the magazine department was very busy and had no time to pay attention to her.

It might also be that they simply didn't like this third-rate educated airborne soldier, so they treated her as invisible, wanting to give her a lesson.

Based on what they said in the restroom, the latter possibility was more likely.

Liang Shi didn't mind. She came here just to find a job. It would be good if she could learn something, and if not, she would do other things.

She wouldn't waste time anyway.

She still had a series of movies she had collected before that she hadn't watched, and there was also the entertainment industry ecosystem in this world that she hadn't understood yet.

Since no one assigned her work, she was quite content.

At three o'clock, the magazine department held a new round of topic selection meeting.

The editor-in-chief was still irritable, taking the new topics and cursing every department bloody.

"We have to meet with the general manager at five o'clock, and we must come up with satisfactory topics. But now, look at what you've submitted! Not a single one is usable! Your thinking is all rigid, isn't it?! Besides those traffic stars on Weibo, can't you come up with new topics? Our luxury goods aren't necessarily all for celebrities. Small-time celebrities can't even afford Dongheng's luxury goods! Do you have brains?!" The editor-in-chief's voice was extremely high and sharp.

Liang Shi stood in the back row. She had no idea what topics everyone had submitted, just mixing in to put on an act.

Unexpectedly, the editor-in-chief suddenly called her out, "Newcomer, tell us what you think about this topic selection."

Liang Shi: "...?"

She pointed at her nose in disbelief, "Me?"

The editor-in-chief nodded, "Yes, you."

Liang Shi was stunned for two seconds. Before she could speak, the editor-in-chief threw that stack of manuscripts on the table, "Don't know anything, what are you here for? To get paid for nothing?! I don't care whose connections got you in here. Since you're in the magazine department, you have to follow the magazine department's rules. Being late for more than half an hour on your first day of work - what kind of work attitude is that?"

"Sorry." Liang Shi indeed had no argument for this point, "I had something urgent today..."

"Did you ask for leave?" The editor-in-chief said, "Not asking for leave is called absenteeism. Three times and you can be directly fired. Moreover, you don't know anything, can't do anything - what are you doing in the magazine department? Do you think our magazine department is for collecting trash?"

Liang Shi: "..."

"Editor-in-chief." Liang Shi frowned, wanting to retort, when someone next to her suddenly tugged at her sleeve, signaling her to be quiet and not confront the editor-in-chief head-on.

But just these two words also made the editor-in-chief explode, "What? Think there's something wrong with what I said? If you don't want to stay in the magazine department, just switch departments, then you won't have to listen to my harsh words. Even if you're the group CEO's daughter, if you come to the magazine department and don't work properly, you still have to get lost!"

Liang Shi: "..."

Her patience had reached its limit.

She wasn't unfamiliar with workplace environments. When she was young and just entered society, she had experienced all kinds of harsh environments.

But they were all about high work intensity, or workplace seniors ganging up to give her a hard time, plus making her buy coffee and drinks, ordering her around to do odd jobs.

After becoming an adult, she changed jobs and learned to protect herself, and had never been called out like this and cursed bloody.

Obviously, this leader was just using work as an excuse to vent emotions.

She had always hated such people.

The colleague next to her was being kind, plus Liang Shi was on her first day, and her own behavior was indeed somewhat problematic.

Being anxious for a moment, not knowing who to ask for leave, she directly slipped out, thinking she could make it back before work time.

So she took a deep breath and endured it.

But unexpectedly, the editor-in-chief said: "I just asked you, what's your opinion on this magazine topic selection? Are you deaf? Can't you hear my question? If this is your work attitude, then get lost early. Our magazine department doesn't support deadweight."

Liang Shi: "..."

She stared tightly at the editor-in-chief, this woman in her early forties with slicked-back hair, thin lips, but very vicious speech.

"What? Not convinced?" The editor-in-chief sneered, "I thought you had some great ability, entering Dongheng with a pheasant diploma, and this is it? Someone who doesn't understand anything, what's wrong with me saying a few words to you? If you don't understand, then learn properly, instead of being absent on your first day."

"First." Liang Shi couldn't help but speak up. She was taller than everyone present, her gaze lightly sweeping over the crowd, her voice also very indifferent, yet naturally carrying the aura of someone in authority, "I apologize for leaving without asking for leave today. I just arrived and didn't have this awareness. It's my problem."

"Second, aside from that point, I don't think I have any problems. Regardless of my education, as long as I've entered Dongheng and this department, it necessarily means I have outstanding qualities. As a leader, shouldn't you be discovering the characteristics of new employees for your department's use? I can communicate in foreign languages, use PS, can also do interviews, including writing interview drafts and helping with photography. You haven't asked about any of these, directly denying me as a person based on my education - isn't that too short-sighted of you?"

Everyone exchanged glances privately, all trembling.

Everyone's eyes revealed one meaning - the newcomer is directly confronting the editor-in-chief like this?

Actually, everyone also felt the editor-in-chief was being somewhat reckless.

Such a newcomer, if airborne, must be a connections hire. Just arrange a workstation for her, assign some idle work, wouldn't that be fine?

Casually supporting her wouldn't be a big deal. Why make such a big fuss about scolding her, even specifically targeting her? This was very low-class.

Who knows when she might hit an iron plate.

However, those who knew the inside story could understand. This editor-in-chief's previous magazine company had an airborne new editor-in-chief who directly squeezed her into a deputy editor position, so after she jumped ship to Dongheng, she particularly hated connections hires and airborne soldiers.

Plus at such a critical moment, she had been agitated for several days already, just lacking an outlet.

The newcomer directly hit the gun muzzle.

Let's see who would win.

Footnotes:

1. 三流學歷 (**sān liú xué lì**) - "Third-rate education" - referring to a degree from a low-quality or poorly regarded university.
2. 空降兵 (**kōng jiàng bīng**) - Literally "paratrooper," but in corporate context refers to someone who is hired or promoted from outside the company into a high position, often implying they got the position through connections rather than merit.
3. 下馬威 (**xià mǎ wēi**) - "Show of strength" or "demonstration of power" - giving someone a harsh lesson or intimidating display on their first encounter.
4. 狗血淋頭 (**gǒu xuè lín tóu**) - Literally "dog blood pouring over the head," meaning to be severely scolded or criticized harshly.
5. 撞槍口 (**zhuàng qiāng kǒu**) - "Hit the gun muzzle" - to run into trouble at the worst possible time, like walking into a line of fire.

Chapter 27-3

Upon hearing this, the editor-in-chief immediately widened her eyes, "I'm short-sighted? I've been in the magazine industry for so many years, my eye for people has always been accurate. Do I need a newcomer like you to teach me how to do my job?"

"Then why haven't you been able to finalize a topic selection?" Liang Shi deftly countered.

Her expression remained very calm throughout, her gaze toward the editor-in-chief carrying a hint of coldness, yet without strong aggression. Even so, it was enough to make people feel her presence, "As an editor-in-chief, shouldn't your responsibility be coordination? As far as I know, the planning department provided you with five topic proposals, each one rejected by you, but the reasons you gave were all 'no novelty,' 'been done before,' 'not good,' but where exactly they're not good, you never say. You just demand everyone keep revising, keep changing, you can't even provide a direction for adjustment. Are you sure you've seriously considered this? Have you respected the creativity of your planning department colleagues? With your demands, even if the magazine needs to go to press, you still won't be able to finalize topics. The magazine will definitely have blank pages¹."

Everyone present gasped.

They all looked at Liang Shi with admiring eyes, seeing only two words in their expressions—warrior.

Finally someone had said what they hadn't dared to say these past few days!

"What bullshit are you talking!" The editor-in-chief became emotional, "If you're so capable, you come up with the topic selection! The topics they came up with were garbage to begin with, showing no professionalism at all. At this rate, having blank pages is inevitable, but what does that have to do with me? You bunch of incapable people—the planning department can't come up with topics, the editorial department's articles are a mess, the advertising department can't attract ads that align with our magazine's concept despite backing from Dongheng. Such a magazine is bound to have problems because the staff is incompetent!"

Everyone's faces changed.

This was practically pointing at everyone's noses and cursing!

But precisely because of Dongheng's prestigious reputation and the high salaries here, no one dared to speak up.

Anyone who spoke up now would truly be the nail that sticks out and gets hammered down²—they'd definitely be fired.

So everyone could only turn their gaze to Liang Shi, watching to see if this newcomer dared to continue the confrontation.

And Liang Shi laughed upon hearing her words.

The editor-in-chief scolded, "What the hell are you laughing at?"

Liang Shi replied calmly, "I'm laughing at you."

Editor-in-chief: "..."

In such a tense atmosphere, someone accidentally laughed.

Then several more people got Liang Shi's cold joke³ and covered their mouths, laughing softly.

The editor-in-chief's sharp gaze swept over them, and they all fell silent again.

Liang Shi said, "Do you know what your current behavior looks like?"

She spoke word by word: "Incompetent rage."

"You've pushed all the responsibility onto your subordinates, thinking you're the most innocent one. But you're the one who rejected all the proposals, and you're not even part of this magazine's target demographic, yet you're arbitrarily judging everything based on your own perspective. How could you possibly select suitable topics this way? In fact, you fundamentally cannot do this magazine well. I think the person who should leave the magazine department most is you." Liang Shi smiled with a hint of charm.

"You!" The editor-in-chief was furious, "You're just a newcomer..."

Before she could finish, Liang Shi interrupted, "Yes, I'm a newcomer, but I know that those in authority should listen widely, should observe and listen more, should respect others' work results. If you were truly a capable leader, even if your subordinates submitted a pile of garbage, you should be able to make that garbage shine again, instead of suppressing your subordinates here, elevating yourself by attacking others. Are you qualified to be a leader? What are your abilities? Cursing people? Or venting your anger on newcomers?"

She asked these questions calmly, but the editor-in-chief's face changed because of these words, looking at her with gritted teeth.

"I've worked in this industry for nearly twenty years. Do I need an inexperienced outsider like you to point fingers at me? Do you understand magazines? Do you know how to make magazines?"

"In 1867, America compiled the first fashion magazine 'HARPER'S BAZAAR,' the world's earliest women's fashion magazine. Initially focused only on clothing, it gradually encompassed beauty, leisure, jewelry and other fields. Mainland China published and distributed its first fashion magazine 'Fashion' in 1980. By the 21st century, print media welcomed its golden age, but with technological advancement, print media went from rise to decline in less than thirty years. Now many print media have shut down, entering the new media era. Electronic publications have much higher circulation than print media, so what are you still being stubborn about? Do you think making magazines just requires ideals?" Liang Shi finished speaking without any emotion, while posing questions to her.

She didn't know much about magazines before, only because she was in that circle, so she was involved in some aspects.

Before coming to work at Dongheng, she deliberately researched materials, looking into magazines' origins and current predicaments, and had some thoughts of her own.

Now she was taking the opportunity to express her thoughts.

"Haiwei Jewelry could launch their own publication in a short time and become a first-class magazine in the industry. Do you think their editor-in-chief achieved industry peak by constantly suppressing subordinates like you, making subordinates work overtime every day revising topic selections?" Liang Shi continued questioning.

"Yes, perhaps you were once an excellent magazine person, but times are changing now. You need traffic, readership, sales figures, and also magazine people's ideals. Shouldn't you be the one to balance these things? If you can't balance them well and need all your subordinates to do everything, then what's the point of having you as editor-in-chief? Is it to pay you money to curse people? Is this Dongheng's work environment?"

Her series of rhetorical questions left the editor-in-chief completely bewildered.

This floor was so quiet you could hear a pin drop.

The editor-in-chief, in her fury, threw a stack of A4 papers directly at her. Liang Shi calmly dodged.

The A4 papers fluttered down like falling snowflakes, scattered all over the floor.

Liang Shi looked at her and continued explaining: "Also, if I had magazine work experience, then I would directly replace your position. I would be airborne as magazine department head, not choose to come here as a small employee."

"Ha." The editor-in-chief angrily cursed, "So you're fucking a connections hire, what's there to be proud of? If you have the ability, fucking push me out directly! What bullshit are you spouting here? If you don't have the ability, go back to work. Coming here to show off to me, right? Showing how impressive you are? If you're the CEO's daughter, why didn't you get airborne directly to the president's office!"

"I came to the magazine department voluntarily," Liang Shi said. "But I came here to work, not to accept personal attacks. I believe all colleagues present feel the same. Everyone has self-respect and can accept being criticized. But I hope you understand that criticism and abuse are not the same word. As a leader, you don't have the right to attack your subordinates. You are depriving everyone present of their personal dignity."

Footnotes:

1. **開天窗 (kāi tiān chuāng)** - Literally "opening skylights," this is a publishing term meaning to have blank spaces or missing content in a publication due to lack of material or content being pulled at the last minute.
2. **槍打出頭鳥 (qiāng dǎ chū tóu niǎo)** - "The gun shoots the bird that sticks its head out" - a Chinese saying meaning that those who stand out or speak up first often become targets and face punishment.
3. **冷笑話 (lěng xiào huà)** - "Cold joke" - refers to a pun, wordplay, or joke that's so bad it's funny, often causing people to groan or laugh despite themselves. In this context, Liang Shi's matter-of-fact "I'm laughing at you" response to "What are you laughing at?" is unexpectedly direct and humorous.

Chapter 27-4

After Liang Shi finished speaking, she suddenly paused. Without waiting for the editor-in-chief to retort, she laughed and said, "Forget it, someone like you probably doesn't understand what personal dignity means."

Editor-in-chief: "...Fuck! What the hell are you talking about?!"

"Just the truth," Liang Shi said. "The truth is always harsh to hear."

The editor-in-chief was furious, "Get out! Get out of the magazine department!"

"No, get out of Dongheng!" the editor-in-chief shouted. "Trash like you doesn't deserve to stay at Dongheng."

"I won't leave," Liang Shi said, taking out her phone. "I recorded the entire meeting today. Every word and action of yours has been documented. I'll forward this recording to the president's office and let them decide. I believe Dongheng won't keep someone like you in the company. As for today's topic selection meeting with the general manager, I think we can present the planning department's marriage feature topic—Must everyone have a BARE when getting married? And positioning Dongheng's consumer base, with the subtitle: Everyone can own a BARE in their lifetime."

BARE was the luxury brand under Dongheng, internationally renowned, also known as Bali in Chinese.

Sometimes people jokingly called it Paris.

"Who are you?" The editor-in-chief sneered, "Really think you're somebody important? What gives you the right to decide topics? Did I nod and agree? Do you know who BARE's consumer base is? Rich people! A BARE silk scarf costs at least ninety thousand yuan. Do you think ordinary people can afford it? This topic was already used five years ago at the 'COCI' new product launch. What is Dongheng doing? Do we need to chew gum that others have already chewed? Are we specifically picking up trash? If you can't come up with innovative ideas, you can shut up! Get out!"

"Even if it's been used, can't it be used again? We can surpass it, we can do it from another angle. Why must we be limited by 'she used it, so I can't use it'? BARE's pricing is high, but does that mean ordinary people can never use high-priced items? Everyone is our potential consumer. Just because they don't have money today doesn't mean they'll never have money. Moreover, giving everyone a luxury dream, supporting everyone's right to own luxury goods—as a company, we should have a broad mind, not confine ourselves within walls."

The editor-in-chief was about to curse her for talking nonsense when applause suddenly rang out from the back.

Crisp applause rang out abruptly in the office area, not very enthusiastic, and only from one person.

The clapping rhythm was slow and steady, yet carried a hint of appreciation.

"Who's that? Are you sick..." The editor-in-chief was about to curse, but when she looked up and saw General Manager Liang, she quickly stopped, her face showing an awkward expression.

When Liang Shi turned around, she not only saw Liang Xinhe but also Xu Qingzhu.

Two of Liang Xinhe's assistants had come with them.

"Still want to curse at me?" Liang Xinhe approached with a smile that didn't reach his eyes, looking at the editor-in-chief. "I didn't know before that Editor-in-Chief Sun had such a big ego¹."

"No, General Manager, let me explain. It's because this newcomer is too ignorant of rules, and the magazine topics keep getting delayed. Without good topics, I was anxious..."

"Alright, no need to explain to me," Liang Xinhe said. "I only look at results. Are the magazine topics finalized?"

Editor-in-Chief Sun's face flushed with embarrassment, "Not yet."

"So what were you all just doing? Having an internal topic selection meeting?" Liang Xinhe asked.

"Yes." Editor-in-Chief Sun completely changed from her previous arrogance, becoming humble and respectful, even servile. "Deciding topics is inherently difficult, and with the deadline approaching, our discussion became somewhat... heated."

"Is that so?" Liang Xinhe still smiled, but no one would consider his smile friendly. "I've been here for a while and heard you constantly cursing at the newcomer."

"No." Editor-in-Chief Sun smiled awkwardly. "The newcomer's ideas were too foolish, so I was teaching her."

"Oh? Really?" Liang Xinhe reached out and patted Editor-in-Chief Sun's shoulder. "I couldn't tell, Editor-in-Chief Sun is so helpful and caring toward subordinates?"

Editor-in-Chief Sun nodded and bowed, "As it should be."

"But how did I hear you telling her to get out?" Liang Xinhe's eyes immediately turned sharp.

Editor-in-Chief Sun: "...Those were just words said in anger."

"What's the newcomer's name? Did she introduce herself? Did she chat with everyone?" Liang Xinhe turned to look at Liang Shi.

Liang Shi coughed softly, "Not yet."

All morning, who had time to care about her?

"Did she do any work?" Liang Xinhe asked.

Liang Shi shook her head, "No."

"Were tasks assigned?" Liang Xinhe asked again.

Liang Shi still shook her head, "...Still no."

Liang Xinhe was much taller than Editor-in-Chief Sun. The male Alpha stood nearly 1.85 meters tall, now looking down at the editor-in-chief from above. "Didn't you say the magazine department was short-staffed? I specifically transferred someone over for you, and this is how you use people? When I hired you, I heard you were good at managing people and had strong work capabilities, so I gave you an annual salary of 400,000 yuan. My requirements aren't very high—I didn't ask you to squeeze out Haiwei Jewelry's magazine and become first-class, just to simply create an electronic publication. Can't you even do that? Did I overestimate your work capabilities?"

"No...I..." Editor-in-Chief Sun immediately stumbled over her words, not knowing how to explain, feeling like she couldn't defend herself.

"The magazine department was too busy, I haven't had time to assign her work yet," Editor-in-Chief Sun said nervously.

She really didn't want to lose this job.

A 400,000 yuan annual salary was already top-tier for this industry. Her salary was higher than all her former colleagues.

Everyone knew she had entered Dongheng and was extremely envious.

Now her heart was anxious beyond measure, and she quickly added, "General Manager Liang, I really didn't do it on purpose. Today was too busy."

"You were too busy to assign her work, but had time to curse her bloody during the topic selection meeting. Is this how you treat the person I transferred to you? Are you dissatisfied with her or with me?" Liang Xinhe's tone was calm, but it scared Editor-in-Chief Sun so much her legs went weak.

Everyone understood—this airborne newcomer was backed by General Manager Liang.

General Manager Liang had come to support her.

No wonder the newcomer was so fearless after arriving, daring to directly confront Editor-in-Chief Sun head-on. So she was backed by a big tree to enjoy the shade².

Everyone cast sympathetic glances at Editor-in-Chief Sun.

But moments later, it turned to schadenfreude.

Served her right for being so arrogant usually. Now she'd kicked an iron plate.

"General Manager Liang, I didn't mean that. Today was just too busy..." Editor-in-Chief Sun was still desperately explaining, trying to excuse herself.

Liang Shi had already stepped forward, "General Manager Liang, I have a recording of today's meeting. You can listen to it, or I can email it to you."

Editor-in-Chief Sun glared at her resentfully, "Is there room for you to speak here?!"

Liang Shi: "...Should there be..."

She paused, looking at Liang Xinhe.

Liang Xinhe gave her an affirmative look, and she said with a hint of pride, "There should be, right? General Manager Liang, what do you think?"

Liang Xinhe nodded, "Of course."

Liang Shi was delighted. With someone backing her up, what couldn't she say?

"I think Editor-in-Chief Sun isn't suitable to work at Dongheng," Liang Shi said. "Her magazine philosophy doesn't align with Dongheng's, and the magazine department hasn't developed well under her leadership. If you really value Editor-in-Chief Sun as talent, you could try transferring her to other departments. But I thought about it—no department needs a professional curser."

Hearing this, Liang Xinhe's mouth curved upward.

Liang Shi said, "So I'll leave the decision to you."

Liang Xinhe looked at Liang Shi with appreciation and relief.

The feeling of a father seeing his daughter finally become successful.

Liang Xinhe didn't waste words and directly announced: "Editor-in-Chief Sun, you're dismissed. Go to Human Resources to collect this month's salary and severance pay."

"General Manager Liang, I really didn't do such things..." Editor-in-Chief Sun said. "Are you really going to fire me for a newcomer? I can lead Dongheng's magazine department to greater heights."

Liang Xinhe looked at her, "I can replace you with someone else and still make Dongheng's magazine department better. In this world, having ability doesn't mean you can do whatever you want. Moreover, in the month you've worked here, I haven't seen your abilities."

Editor-in-Chief Sun: "..."

She glared at Liang Shi resentfully, "You wait and see!"

Liang Shi shrugged helplessly and shook her head.

Just the impotent rage of a clown.

This farce quickly ended. Liang Xinhe told everyone in the magazine department to return to their workstations and instructed the planning team leader to present all topic proposals at the 5 PM meeting for discussion, encouraging them not to be afraid and to bravely express their opinions.

Liang Xinhe's approach to handling matters was completely different from Editor-in-Chief Sun's, making the planning team happy.

God knows how badly they'd been cursed by Editor-in-Chief Sun these past few days.

One girl hadn't slept for three days. Every day at work, her eyes were red and swollen because when she went home to sleep, she always felt someone was cursing at her, making her too scared to sleep and could only cry.

Editor-in-Chief Sun returned to her office to pack up.

While packing, she saw the resume on the desk—Liang Shi's, which she had handed in that morning. She hadn't even looked at it and just threw it on the desk.

Now furious, she picked up the resume intending to tear it up to vent her anger.

But she stopped when she saw the name.

The name column read—Liang Shi.

Liang Shi, Liang Xinhe, Liang Xinzhou.

All surnamed Liang.

A suspicion formed in her mind.

She suddenly became somewhat panicked, but still crumpled Liang Shi's resume into a ball and threw it in the trash like garbage.

Footnotes:

1. **官架子 (guān jià zi)** - "Official airs" or "bureaucratic attitude" - refers to someone who acts pompous or arrogant due to their position of authority.
2. **背靠大樹好乘涼 (bèi kào dà shù hǎo chéng liáng)** - "It's good to enjoy shade with your back against a big tree" - a Chinese idiom meaning it's advantageous to have powerful backing or support.

Chapter 27-6

//

Liang Shi hadn't expected Liang Xinhe and Xu Qingzhu to suddenly show up.

But she was also grateful that Liang Xinhe came in time.

Otherwise, she would have had to argue with that Editor-in-Chief Sun for much longer.

Liang Xinhe had his assistant order afternoon tea for everyone, then left the magazine department.

Leaving with him were Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu.

Once they were out of the magazine department and in a place with no one around, Liang Shi asked with a smile, "Second Brother, why did you suddenly come over?"

"Of course it was sister-in-law¹ looking for you," Liang Xinhe glanced at her. "Don't tell me you really thought I came specifically to see you?"

"Well, I'm not that narcissistic," Liang Shi sheepishly touched her nose tip, still unable to hide her smile. "But thanks anyway."

"Thanks for what," Liang Xinhe said. "I was just removing parasites from the company."

Liang Shi nodded, "Right, right, right."

She could see it now—Liang Xinhe was just a tsundere².

He clearly cared about this sister, yet insisted on pretending to be indifferent.

"Alright, stop being sarcastic with me," Liang Xinhe said. "Sister-in-law is looking for you about something. You two chat, I'm going upstairs."

"Okay, thanks Second Brother," Liang Shi said happily.

Liang Xinhe walked a few steps, then suddenly stopped and turned back to look at her, "Liang Shi."

Liang Shi was about to talk to Xu Qingzhu when she heard him call her and looked up, "Hm?"

"You did well today," Liang Xinhe said. "Keep up the good work."

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Xinhe approved of her?

She immediately smiled in response, "Got it!"

Liang Xinhe took the elevator and left, leaving only her and Xu Qingzhu in the corridor.

"Why did you suddenly come?" Liang Shi asked. "Did something happen at the company?"

"No." Xu Qingzhu let out a light breath, "Wait, let me sort my thoughts."

Liang Shi: "...Okay."

But during this gap, Liang Shi's phone vibrated slightly.

She looked and saw it was a transfer message from Liang Xinhe, who had directly transferred 100,000 yuan to her with the note: [Take sister-in-law out for something good to eat, look how thin she's gotten.]

Liang Shi: "..."

Do all you rich people just throw money around at the drop of a hat?

Liang Xinhe was really a sister-doting maniac³.

Just because she'd improved a little, was he so happy his tail was practically wagging in the sky?

Liang Shi replied to him: [Got it, thanks Second Brother.]

A few seconds later, another transfer of 100,000 yuan came through.

Liang Xinhe: [Buy sister-in-law some pretty clothes, and yourself too. What you're wearing looks terrible and embarrasses the Liang family.]

Liang Shi: "..."

Her clothes were all carefully coordinated and very suitable for work.

Moreover, she deliberately didn't wear designer brands.

If she wore a full set of luxury brands to work, everyone would know her family background wasn't simple.

But after today, everyone should know anyway.

Liang Shi chose to accept her fate.

She couldn't just stand there being cursed at anyway. Not going up and punching her twice was already showing restraint.

Liang Shi replied: [Okay, thanks Second Brother.]

A few seconds later, Liang Xinhe transferred another 300,000 yuan.

Liang Shi: "?"

Liang Xinhe: [Don't be stingy, or people will think the Liang family went bankrupt.]

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Shi: [Okay.]

Looking at the 500,000 yuan transferred to her, Liang Shi didn't know whether to laugh or cry.

Although that mother Qiu Zimin was a bit perverted, this second brother Liang Xinhe was indeed quite nice.

Liang Shi put away her phone and looked at Xu Qingzhu.

Footnotes:

1. **妹妻 (mèi qī)** - "Sister-in-law" - specifically refers to a younger brother's wife. Since Liang Shi is the youngest in the Liang family, Xu Qingzhu would be called "妹妻" by the older siblings.
2. **傲娇 (ào jiāo)** - "Tsundere" - a personality type that describes someone who acts cold, hostile, or indifferent on the surface but is actually caring and affectionate underneath. This term originates from Japanese anime/manga culture but has been adopted into Chinese internet slang.
3. **寵妹狂魔 (chǒng mèi kuáng mó)** - "Sister-doting maniac" - describes someone who extremely dotes on and spoils their younger sister, often to an excessive degree.

Chapter 27-7

Xu Qingzhu quickly sorted out her thoughts, just waiting for Liang Shi to finish her business.

She had a reason for leaving work midway.

Today was her first day at Minghui Jewelry Design Department, taking the position of Deputy Design Director.

After arriving, there were many things to handle, but unlike Liang Shi, she didn't encounter anyone looking for trouble.

Everyone knew she was the eldest daughter of the Xu family. No one dared to provoke her, and even the Design Director would give her some face.

She had been busy all day, only taking a brief rest after lunch before diving back into work.

In the afternoon, while coming out to get some tea, she heard colleagues discussing today's news. Initially, she didn't pay much attention, but then she heard a familiar name—Chen Liuying.

Then she heard Bai Weiwei's name.

She immediately perked up her ears, and everything that had happened to Bai Weiwei reached her ears.

She didn't even have time to return to her office before taking out her phone to search for Bai Weiwei's name, and the related news entered her view.

Seeing the words "Bai Weiwei jumped off building," her heart skipped a few beats.

She nervously called Bai Weiwei, but the phone was still turned off.

She tried calling Zhao Xuning, but couldn't get through, and her private number wasn't answered either.

She also called Liang Shi, but no one answered.

Originally, she wanted to drive directly to the hospital, but online it said Bai Weiwei had been transferred to a private hospital. She figured that even if she rushed to the hospital, she wouldn't be able to see Bai Weiwei, so she turned around at the intersection and came to Dongheng instead.

She didn't yet know which department Liang Shi had gone to, so she had to contact Liang Xinhe via WeChat.

Liang Xinhe thought Liang Shi was bullying her and was furious, saying he would definitely teach Liang Shi a good lesson.

After Xu Qingzhu explained, she came to the magazine department.

But unexpectedly, as soon as she arrived, she heard Liang Shi arguing with the editor-in-chief.

If it had been according to the original Liang Shi's personality, she probably would have smashed up the magazine department and pinned that editor-in-chief to the ground for a beating.

But today, Liang Shi stood there confidently, rebutting the other party with reason and evidence, leaving her speechless.

Every point she raised was convincing, and her voice was very pleasant, with a steadiness different from before.

Footnotes:

1. **副部长 (fù bù zhǎng)** - "Deputy Director" - In Chinese corporate structure, this refers to a second-in-command position within a department, ranking below the department head/director.
2. **给面子 (gěi miàn zi)** - "Give face" - A Chinese concept meaning to show respect or deference to someone, often due to their status, position, or relationships. In this context, even the department head would treat Xu Qingzhu with respect due to her family background.

Chapter 27-8

Xu Qingzhu saw Liang Shi shining in the workplace and became so absorbed listening that she didn't call out to her.

Now that it was over, she almost forgot why she had come looking for Liang Shi. Fortunately, after calming her emotions slightly, she remembered.

Afraid of being overheard, she lowered her voice to ask, "How is Bai Weiwei doing now?"

Liang Shi didn't think to hide anything from her—she would find out sooner or later anyway—so she directly told her the current situation, "She's out of danger, still under observation. When she can receive visitors, Zhao Xuning will let us know."

"Are those things said online all true?" Xu Qingzhu asked, "Was Weiwei that night... by someone..."

She couldn't even say the word "violated."

"No," Liang Shi said. "That room closed at ten o'clock, and Zhao Xuning and I went to find you at ten-ten. Ten minutes—what could they do?"

"But in that photo online, Weiwei's expression looked very wrong," Xu Qingzhu said.

"Because something was mixed into the drinks that night, and you both drank it," Liang Shi said selectively, trying to ensure everything she said was true. "Her condition was more serious than yours. The aphrodisiac caused her heat period to come early, so she looked very abnormal. Zhao Xuning rescued her in time and gave her suppressants, so no major harm was done."

"Then why did Weiwei jump off the building?"

"Zhao Xuning said it was because she fought with her girlfriend."

"She has a girlfriend? Wasn't she always waiting for Zhao Xuning?"

"..."

Liang Shi thought Xu Qingzhu knew.

Turns out Xu Qingzhu didn't know at all.

She could only awkwardly touch her nose, "I'm not clear on the specifics either. Zhao Xuning seemed to have been watching over her for quite a while and sounded tired, so I didn't ask much."

Xu Qingzhu clenched her fist, then suddenly changed the subject to ask, "So that night, was I violated? Did you help me undress?"

Liang Shi: "..."

"No," Liang Shi said. "When I went in, you were wearing a camisole, your underwear was still on, your pants were intact."

When talking about these things, images of that night's scenery appeared in Liang Shi's mind.

Her gaze moved down slightly, and with just a casual glance she could see Xu Qingzhu's upper body.

Her shirt buttons were slightly tight.

Liang Shi looked away.

"Did we have relations?" Xu Qingzhu could judge for herself whether her body showed any abnormalities, but to be safe, she still asked.

"Ah..." Liang Shi paused slightly, raising her hand to touch her ear, then answered, "No."

"You're lying," Xu Qingzhu said with certainty.

"I'm not lying," Liang Shi suddenly moved closer to her, lowering her voice, "Whether anything happened, doesn't your own body know?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Xu Qingzhu stared at her intently.

A few seconds later, Liang Shi broke, helplessly saying, "You just kissed my cheek, does that count?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Xu Qingzhu had originally been asking her very seriously and properly, but she hadn't expected such an answer.

Moreover, they were in a corner of the corridor, with her back slightly against the wall, and when Liang Shi moved closer, she was pressed into the corner.

The Alpha's scent was very pleasant—a light fragrance of white silver needle tea¹.

It smelled comfortable and reassuring.

Her tone wasn't as tough and cold as it had been in the office, but carried a hint of softness, like acting spoiled, and also like helpless indulgence.

There was also a bit of shyness mixed in, because when she said the word "kiss," her voice trembled slightly.

The Alpha's breath fell on her face as she spoke, making her heartbeat suddenly accelerate, her downcast eyelashes fluttering constantly.

She gently pushed Liang Shi, but her hand happened to land on her softness.

Alpha breasts weren't as large as Omegas'.

Some Alphas were even completely flat.

Liang Shi was an exception.

Her height was outstanding among Alphas, and even her chest development was better than average Alphas.

Soft, and it felt very good.

When Xu Qingzhu gently pushed, Liang Shi couldn't help but let out a muffled groan.

Liang Shi: "..."

Xu Qingzhu's hands were small, so she couldn't really feel much force when she pushed gently, but she happened to push a sensitive area.

Even a little force would be keenly felt.

Liang Shi hadn't controlled herself.

Not only that, her ears felt like they were on fire.

This was the first time she'd been touched by a girl... especially since this person was her nominal wife.

Footnotes:

1. **白毫銀針 (bái háo yín zhēn)** - "White Hair Silver Needle" - A premium type of white tea from China, known for its delicate, sweet fragrance. It's considered one of the most prized varieties of Chinese tea, made from unopened tea buds covered in fine white hairs.

Chapter 27-9

Liang Shi stepped back half a pace. Xu Qingzhu was momentarily stunned, her hand still suspended in mid-air, looking somewhat awkward.

Xu Qingzhu's hand even grasped at the air, like playing piano—just an empty gesture, but in Liang Shi's eyes, she had already imagined other meanings.

"..."

She felt a surge of heat rising in her abdomen.

The scene became somewhat awkward.

Liang Shi nervously pinched her ear, "Just pretend I didn't say anything."

Xu Qingzhu looked at her and suddenly smiled.

She shrugged, "Sorry, I drank too much that day and wasn't thinking clearly."

Liang Shi immediately waved her hands, "It's fine, it's fine. I didn't dare do anything to you."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

This sounded very cowardly, making Xu Qingzhu want to laugh. It also relieved much of her earlier tension about Bai Weiwei. She deliberately teased her, "Even if you had done something to me, I wouldn't remember anyway, so I'd just have to take your word for it."

Liang Shi: "...?"

"Heaven can bear witness, I really didn't do anything," Liang Shi earnestly explained. "Your sister was still in the car that day. What could I have done?"

"If my sister wasn't there, would you have done something?" Xu Qingzhu smoothly countered.

Liang Shi: "...I wouldn't."

Her voice trailed off, carrying a hint of guilt as she said quietly, "I'm not that much of a gentleman either."

Xu Qingzhu heard this and found it amusing.

Why did this person seem quite innocent?

She deliberately teased her, "What did you say? I didn't hear clearly."

Liang Shi: "..."

She was speechless, and after being stuck for a few seconds, said firmly, "I'm an upright gentleman who wouldn't take advantage of someone's vulnerability."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Xu Qingzhu laughed and covered her forehead, "Oh, thank you."

Liang Shi: "?"

She felt like Xu Qingzhu was being somewhat sarcastic.

"Really, just trust me," Liang Shi said. "If I had really done something to you, I'd definitely be chasing after you demanding you take responsibility."

Xu Qingzhu restrained her smile and raised an eyebrow threateningly, "You try it?"

Liang Shi: "...I was wrong."

Her quick submission gave their interaction a hint of flirtation.

Like a young couple bantering playfully.

However, Xu Qingzhu didn't continue dwelling on this topic. She still trusted the current Liang Shi relatively well.

She turned the conversation to Bai Weiwei, "So according to Zhao Xuning, Weiwei jumped off the building because she fought with her girlfriend over the Huayue International incident and became emotionally agitated?"

Liang Shi nodded, "Probably."

Xu Qingzhu let out a heavy sigh, guiltily pressing her temples¹, "I should have taken her away directly that day."

"Then why didn't you?" Liang Shi pressed.

Xu Qingzhu paused slightly, then suddenly smiled, "I guess I thought nothing would happen, and besides, Weiwei really wanted to secure that movie for Chen Liuying—one that could compete for the Golden Horse Awards²."

She just didn't want to hold Bai Weiwei back.

She hadn't expected the consequences to be so serious.

"Who sent you the text message asking you to go that day?" Liang Shi asked.

"A man using Weiwei's phone to text me," Xu Qingzhu said.

"What kind of man? Do you know which company he's from?" Liang Shi continued asking.

Xu Qingzhu tried hard to remember. Her memory when not drunk was very clear. She took out her phone to search online, then handed it to Liang Shi, "It's this person."

The biography showed his title as director and producer, with multiple award-winning works and a very high status in the domestic film and television industry.

Liang Shi memorized the name, planning to investigate privately.

Xu Qingzhu asked, "Is there a problem?"

"What did he specifically ask you to do?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu thought her question was naive, "A male Alpha calling a female Omega—what else could it be? He wanted me to drink with clients."

When talking about these things, Xu Qingzhu frowned slightly, disgust flashing in her eyes.

But before Liang Shi could say anything, Xu Qingzhu first assured her, "I won't rashly go to such places again. I remember everything you said to me yesterday. If there's really necessary business entertainment, I'll call you. Thank you in advance."

"No problem," Liang Shi patted her shoulder, looking like a revolutionary comrade³, "I'm an Alpha, so I don't get drunk easily."

Xu Qingzhu smiled and said nothing more.

She lowered her head to press her phone, wanting to call Zhao Xuning but afraid of interfering with her work.

She really wanted to go see Bai Weiwei right now, but visiting wasn't allowed yet.

She could only worry pointlessly here.

After a while, Xu Qingzhu said, "I'm going back to work. Remember to notify me if you have any news."

Liang Shi nodded, "Okay, work hard."

Xu Qingzhu opened the stairwell door, "You too."

Before leaving, she turned around like Liang Shi had done and praised, "Liang Shi, you look super cool when you're working."

Liang Shi: "..."

She smiled confidently, "Of course."

Footnotes:

1. **太陽穴 (tài yáng xué)** - "Temples" - the area on the sides of the forehead. In Chinese culture, pressing or massaging the temples is a common way to relieve headaches or stress.
2. **金馬獎 (jīn mǎ jiǎng)** - "Golden Horse Awards" - The most prestigious film awards in the Chinese-speaking world, often considered the Chinese equivalent of the Oscars. Originally established in Taiwan, they recognize excellence in Chinese-language cinema.
3. **革命戰友 (gé mìng zhàn yǒu)** - "Revolutionary comrade" - A term that evokes the spirit of solidarity and mutual support, often used in Chinese contexts to describe close allies or partners who support each other through challenges, with historical roots in Communist revolutionary terminology.

Chapter 27-10

//

After Xu Qingzhu left, Liang Shi sent another text message to Zhao Xuning: [Xu Qingzhu knows about Bai Weiwei's situation. If you have any new developments, remember to notify us at any time. If you need help, just say so.]

Zhao Xuning quickly replied: [Okay, thank you.]

Human interactions should be kept just right¹.

Liang Shi didn't want to return to the magazine department and cause trouble for her colleagues yet.

Having just caused such a big commotion, if she went back, it would definitely attract "spectators" among her colleagues.

But there was still a topic selection meeting at five o'clock, and colleagues needed to rush their manuscripts and prepare PPTs for presentation.

She looked at the time—it was already 4:40 PM. She might as well wait another twenty minutes and go directly to the meeting.

Taking advantage of this gap, she went to the restroom.

When she came out, she happened to encounter Editor-in-Chief Sun, who had just finished processing her resignation at the Human Resources department.

She stood at the washbasin washing her hands, soap foam gently sliding over her skin, while Editor-in-Chief Sun stood to one side, looking at her like a venomous snake, filled with resentment.

She ignored her.

Liang Shi calmly washed her hands, then pulled a paper towel from the side, unhurriedly dried her hands, and accurately threw the crumpled paper into the trash bin.

She tucked the loose hair by her ears behind them, glanced sideways at Editor-in-Chief Sun, and started to leave in her high heels.

But Editor-in-Chief Sun suddenly asked through gritted teeth, "Who exactly are you?"

Liang Shi turned back to look at her.

Editor-in-Chief Sun's slicked hair had come loose, making her look somewhat disheveled. "Even if I die, I should die knowing the truth."

Her expression had become twisted, "Who exactly did you rely on to get in here?"

Liang Shi was taller than her, and just standing there was enough to give her a strong sense of oppression.

Liang Shi smiled slightly, "Then let me introduce myself. My name is Liang Shi."

Editor-in-Chief Sun said resentfully, "I know! What's your relationship with General Manager Liang?!"

Liang Shi's voice remained gentle, yet carried an aloof sense of superiority, "My surname is Liang, and his surname is also Liang. Dongheng Group..."

She paused, then sneered, "Was always owned by people surnamed Liang."

"Ha." Editor-in-Chief Sun laughed coldly. "So I just lost to a connections hire². What if Dongheng Group is owned by the Liangs? Who doesn't know that the Liang family's young lady has a trash education, is trash as a person—she's just complete garbage."

Since she was already fired anyway, Editor-in-Chief Sun had nothing to fear.

She stared at Liang Shi and cursed viciously, "Trash doesn't deserve to live in this world."

"Is that so?" Liang Shi didn't get angry. She just glanced at her lightly, "If you know the Liang family's young lady is such a piece of garbage, you should know I have a very bad temper. Beating you up here—probably no one would know."

Hearing this, Editor-in-Chief Sun was scared and stepped back, "What are you doing? I'll call the police! I'll send you to jail!"

"No one saw me hit you," Liang Shi approached her. "I can make the surveillance here break."

Editor-in-Chief Sun: "..."

Seeing her cower, Liang Shi suddenly laughed lightly and stepped back, "Hitting you would dirty my hands."

Liang Shi looked at her and said seriously, "You didn't lose to the Liang family's young lady. With your work methods, you would have crashed and burned eventually. Whether I'm the Liang family's young lady or not, no leader would approve of your work style. Getting fired was inevitable for you."

Liang Shi's voice softened, "You lost to yourself."

Editor-in-Chief Sun stared at her dumbfounded.

At that moment, something seemed to deeply strike her heart.

//

When Liang Shi returned for the meeting, Liang Xinhe had also just arrived. She sat on the sidelines, taking out her notebook to start taking meeting notes.

Before the meeting began, she transferred half of the 500,000 yuan that Liang Xinhe had just sent her to Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu: [?]

Liang Shi: [Second Brother gave it to me, I'm splitting it with you.]

Xu Qingzhu: [...Why?]

Liang Shi: [Joint marital property³.]

After a while, Liang Shi transferred another 200,000 yuan to her.

Xu Qingzhu: [Did Second Brother give you more?]

Liang Shi: [No, this is from my own half.]

Xu Qingzhu: [...You're still 50,000 short.]

Liang Shi: [?]

She poked at the screen to reply: [Got to leave myself some pocket money, right?]

Xu Qingzhu: [...]

Liang Xinhe knocked on the table, "Let's start the meeting."

Liang Shi immediately put her phone on silent and tossed it aside.

Footnotes:

1. **點到為止 (diǎn dào wéi zhǐ)** - "Stop at just the right point" - A Chinese idiom meaning to do something in moderation, knowing when to stop, or keeping interactions at an appropriate level without going overboard.
2. **關係戶 (guān xi hù)** - "Connections hire" - Someone who gets a job or position through personal relationships or connections rather than merit, often viewed negatively in professional contexts.
3. **夫妻共同財產 (fū qī gòng tóng cái chǎn)** - "Joint marital property" - In Chinese marriage law, this refers to assets acquired during marriage that belong equally to both spouses, regardless of who earned the money. Liang Shi is jokingly applying this concept to the money her brother gave her.

Chapter 27-11

//

On her first day at work, she had caused a storm in the company. Before work was even over, every department knew that a new employee had been airborne into the magazine department and directly fired the usually volatile Editor-in-Chief Sun.

This left a vacancy in the magazine department's management.

Currently, everyone was speculating whether the new employee would be directly promoted to department head.

But there was no confirmed news yet.

Liang Xinhe held meetings very efficiently. He concisely finalized the first issue's topic selection for the magazine—deciding on the one Liang Shi had previously suggested: "Everyone can own one BARE in their lifetime."

After finalizing the topic, he assigned tasks to each team leader, but didn't mention the new department head position, telling each team to come directly to him if they had any issues.

Liang Shi didn't work overtime on her first day. After work, she drove home.

On the road, she received a call from Zhao Xuning, saying Bai Weiwei had woken up and visits could be arranged. She had already sent the room number via text message.

Liang Shi acknowledged this and turned around to drive to Xu Qingzhu's company, calling her along the way.

But no one answered.

After reaching the building of her company, Liang Shi called her again. Still no answer.

"..."

Seriously?

This was supposed to be staying in contact at all times?

Were they supposed to communicate by carrier pigeon¹?

Liang Shi sighed helplessly and had to enter the company.

The receptionist was new and didn't recognize her. When she said she was looking for Xu Qingzhu, the receptionist asked if she had an appointment. She shook her head, then confidently countered, "Do I need an appointment to see my own wife?"

Though she was fake, her identity was real.

While feeling guilty saying this, she also pretended to be confident, not letting anyone see through her.

The receptionist immediately called Xu Qingzhu's office. No one answered.

Receptionist: "..."

She was afraid the person might be lying, but also afraid she wasn't.

After all, this was the young lady's wife. As a working person, she couldn't afford to offend anyone.

After much consideration, she tentatively asked, "How about I take you upstairs to have a look?"

Liang Shi nodded, "Okay, thank you for the trouble."

The design department was on the tenth floor. When Liang Shi and the receptionist stood in the elevator, the receptionist couldn't help stealing glances at her, worried about making a mistake. But she also felt that such a premium Alpha, whether in temperament or appearance, matched well with their young lady. Surely it couldn't be fake?

But this was just her speculation.

She nervously led Liang Shi upstairs, only to find the design department workstations were all empty.

However, the lights were on in the large conference room. Through the frosted glass, they could see it was packed with people, apparently all in a meeting. She asked Liang Shi to wait a moment.

This wait lasted an hour.

Liang Shi: "..."

She seemed to understand why Xu Qingzhu could bring Minghui Jewelry back from the brink and eventually take it public.

The slackers had already left work, while the diligent were still in meetings.

The meeting lasted until nearly eight o'clock.

Employees came out of the office carrying file folders, looking like wilted eggplants², but each department was fulfilling their duties with fairly coordinated cooperation.

It seemed tonight would be another sleepless night for them.

Liang Shi roughly counted the number of people and ordered late-night snacks for everyone.

Footnotes:

1. **飛鴿傳書 (fēi gē chuán shū)** - "Carrier pigeon messaging" - A traditional Chinese method of long-distance communication using trained pigeons. Here it's used sarcastically to express frustration about the lack of modern communication.
2. **霜打了的茄子 (shuāng dǎ le de qié zi)** - "Eggplants hit by frost" - A Chinese idiom describing people who look wilted, dejected, or exhausted, like vegetables that have been damaged by cold weather.

Chapter 27-12

Xu Qingzhu stayed in the office for a while longer before coming out.

She had her work badge hanging around her neck and wasn't wearing a coat—just a simple shirt. But unlike at home, she was now wearing gold-rimmed glasses, her hair casually tied in a ponytail with a few strands falling across her forehead. Though she looked somewhat tired, she appeared even more coldly beautiful.

She surveyed the office area, her gaze settling on the edge, where she froze for a moment.

Liang Shi raised her hand to wave at her.

Xu Qingzhu revealed a gentle smile.

Her lips curved upward slightly.

It was just a gentle smile, but it instantly shattered the cold beauty filter.

She walked toward Liang Shi in her high heels, and the receptionist breathed a sigh of relief—good, she hadn't brought the wrong person.

"How did you come here?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

"You didn't answer when I called, so I could only come over," Liang Shi said.

"Sorry, I was in a meeting." Xu Qingzhu took out her phone from her pocket and pressed it twice, but the screen wouldn't light up—it was dead.

"Zhao Xuning said Weiwei woke up and we can visit her," Liang Shi lowered her voice and asked, "Are you done with work here?"

"Not yet," Xu Qingzhu said, "but I can leave."

Weiwei was the most important thing right now.

Liang Shi said to her, "Is your department working overtime tonight?"

"Yes, the new product launch is coming up soon, and several products haven't been finalized yet." Although Xu Qingzhu had only been here for her first day, she had already figured out the entire department and integrated into the work process.

"I ordered midnight snacks for everyone," Liang Shi said.

Upon hearing this, Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow and gave her a thumbs up.

Liang Shi: "..."

She was quite pleased with herself.

Xu Qingzhu turned around and clapped her hands, and everyone's gaze immediately turned to her.

Xu Qingzhu's clear voice rang out, "Everyone has worked hard today. Those who have finished their work can go home, and those who haven't can take it home to finish—just complete it on time. Overtime is voluntary, with double pay, and no later than 12 o'clock. I..."

She paused, "My wife ordered midnight snacks for everyone. When you get tired from overtime later, you can eat. Thank you all for your hard work."

After speaking, she bowed to everyone.

Everyone in the office was stunned.

After all, working overtime was normal for designers.

Before Xu Qingzhu arrived, they often worked overtime, but they never had this kind of treatment!

Midnight snacks? Double pay? And she would tell them they worked hard?

The department head would only say this was what you should do for your salary.

Everyone suddenly understood—this was the demeanor of a young lady from a wealthy family.

Someone started clapping, and the design department erupted in thunderous applause.

Someone bold enough laughed and said, "Thank you, sister-in-law."

Others shouted: "Sister-in-law is beautiful and kind-hearted."

"Wishing sister-in-law and the young miss a long and happy life together."

"..."

For a moment, everything was chaotic.

Footnotes

¹ **Work badge (工牌):** Employee identification card worn around the neck in Chinese workplaces

² **Sister-in-law (嫂子):** In Chinese culture, employees often use familial terms to address their boss's spouse as a sign of respect and closeness

³ **Young miss (大小姐):** A respectful term for a wealthy family's daughter, indicating Xu Qingzhu's high social status

Chapter 27-13

//

Liang Shi drove while Xu Qingzhu sat in the passenger seat.

Even while sitting in the car, she was still working on new proposals.

Liang Shi tried her best to drive smoothly.

When they arrived at the hospital at 9:10, Xu Qingzhu's body hadn't fully recovered yet, and she had taken on a heavy workload. She had just finished the proposal and hadn't even had time to save it before she fell asleep leaning against the window.

The car stopped in the underground parking garage, and as soon as it came to a halt, Xu Qingzhu opened her eyes. Her voice was drowsy and hoarse: "Are we here?"

Liang Shi nodded, "Yes, are you okay?"

"I'm fine." Xu Qingzhu yawned as she saved and sent the proposal, then tossed her laptop into the back seat, unbuckled her seatbelt and got out of the car. "Let's go see Weiwei first."

The two went upstairs together.

Thanks to Zhao Xuning's connections, Bai Weiwei was staying in a VIP suite on the top floor, with a full set of security facilities to prevent her from attempting to jump again.

When they went up, an argument was erupting in the hallway.

Zhao Xuning's cold voice was kept as low as possible, but her anger was still audible: "You've already driven her to jump off a building, isn't that enough? Do you really need her to die to be satisfied?"

"This is between the two of us, it has nothing to do with you," another female voice sounded harsh and cold. "You must explain to me what happened that night, otherwise I'm wearing this green hat¹ for no reason."

"I've already explained it to you," Zhao Xuning said. "When I found her, she hadn't been violated, and I was just standing in a friend's position, bringing her back and giving her inhibitor injections. Her emotions were already unstable, and if you keep pressing her like this, are you trying to drive her to death?"

"Am I trying to drive her to death? She's the one trying to drive me to death," the female voice became increasingly agitated. "Who doesn't know she used to have feelings for you? She must be thrilled this time, putting a green hat on me. Damn it, Bai Weiwei, I was wrong to love you!"

"Can't these things be discussed later?" Zhao Xuning struggled to control her temper. "She's a patient right now, just came down from the operating table. Can we discuss emotional issues later?"

"Ha, of course you can. You're the one who put a green hat on me, not the other way around! Of course you're fine with it."

"..."

"Zhao Xuning," Liang Shi called out, and the argument suddenly stopped.

Xu Qingzhu jogged over and stood beside Zhao Xuning, looking at the person across from them and frowning: "Chen Liuying?"

Chen Liuying saw her and was stunned for a few seconds, then raised an eyebrow: "Xu Qingzhu?"

"Yes," Xu Qingzhu said. "This is a hospital room. Can you please stop arguing? Arguing won't solve the problem right now. Why don't you use this time to contact your studio and suppress all the negative news related to you? When Weiwei recovers, her work will be a bit easier."

Chen Liuying was taken aback. She didn't argue with Xu Qingzhu like she had with Zhao Xuning, but said impatiently, "I know."

Then she sat on a bench in the corridor and pulled out a cigarette from her pocket.

Zhao Xuning kindly reminded her, "Sorry, this is a no-smoking area."

Chen Liuying: "..."

Xu Qingzhu and Liang Shi went into the room to visit Bai Weiwei, while Zhao Xuning waited outside.

Bai Weiwei was already awake.

She had jumped from a window, but it wasn't as exaggerated as reported online. She had just argued with Chen Liuying and jumped directly from the fifth floor. When she landed, she fell onto soft grass, only injuring her leg, which required surgery. One leg was now suspended in the air.

Her face also had minor scrapes, nothing too serious.

She sat on the hospital bed with vacant eyes, holding an apple in her hand.

When Xu Qingzhu saw her like this, she couldn't help but want to cry. She immediately stepped forward and hugged her tightly: "Weiwei."

Bai Weiwei's stiff body moved slightly, slowly turning around. A tear fell as she called out hoarsely, "Bamboo²."

As if she wanted to vent all the grievances she had suffered since waking up, she went from soft whimpering to quiet sobbing, then to loud wailing.

Xu Qingzhu kept comforting her: "It's okay, I'm here. Nothing happened that night, don't be sad, it's not our fault."

Bai Weiwei just cried.

Liang Shi had always been unable to bear such scenes, and it made her want to cry too.

She handed tissues to the two Omegas who were hugging and crying, then left the room, giving the space to the two close friends.

Then she found Zhao Xuning to understand the situation.

Zhao Xuning didn't hide anything and told her the whole story truthfully.

It was actually quite simple. Bai Weiwei was in a relationship with one of her artists, but they hadn't gone public. Chen Liuying, known as "the entertainment industry's number one dominating Alpha," had a bad temper, was petty, and extremely jealous. That persona was also packaged by Bai Weiwei for her.

That day when Zhao Xuning brought Bai Weiwei back to the hospital, they happened to run into Chen Liuying, who had come for a check-up for a sprained foot.

Originally, Bai Weiwei wasn't wearing clothes, and Zhao Xuning had wrapped her own clothes around her. Omegas in heat would be attracted to Alpha pheromones. Zhao Xuning had always been conservative and had long hidden her own pheromones, but she couldn't suppress Bai Weiwei's pheromones.

After encountering Chen Liuying, the latter was angry that Bai Weiwei was being held by her and jealous that Bai Weiwei was wrapped in her clothes. So in a fit of anger, she tore off Bai Weiwei's clothes, only to discover that Bai Weiwei was naked.

She immediately became furious and insisted that Bai Weiwei had cheated.

Footnotes

¹ **Green hat (绿帽子):** A Chinese expression meaning "cuckold" - being cheated on by one's partner. Wearing a "green hat" means being the victim of infidelity.

² **Bamboo (竹子):** Xu Qingzhu's nickname among close friends, derived from the "zhu" (竹) character in her name, which means bamboo.

Chapter 27-14

After Bai Weiwei was given an inhibitor injection and fell into a deep sleep, Chen Liuying wanted to argue with Zhao Xuning.

Zhao Xuning explained to her, but she didn't believe it.

Bai Weiwei's physical condition was slightly better than Xu Qingzhu's. She rested for a day and woke up, but on the day she woke up, Chen Liuying had a big fight with her.

The argument was so intense that Bai Weiwei became emotionally agitated and the inhibitor lost its effectiveness.

After Zhao Xuning gave her another inhibitor injection, she repeatedly warned Chen Liuying not to provoke her anymore.

But when Bai Weiwei woke up the next day, Chen Liuying fought with her again.

This caused Bai Weiwei to have a moment of despair. She directly pushed open the window and jumped down from the fifth floor. Bystanders witnessed this, filmed a video, and posted it online.

This then triggered the online drama that followed.

After hearing the whole story, Liang Shi: "..."

Mixed feelings.jpg

She hadn't expected that while Bai Weiwei was quite fierce when scolding the original owner, she herself had poor judgment in people and found such a scumbag woman?

Perhaps it was... those involved are often confused, while bystanders see clearly?

Liang Shi couldn't really judge.

She asked Zhao Xuning, "So how are you handling this?"

Zhao Xuning leaned against the wall and shook her head, "Just like this."

Her calm voice carried a hint of fatigue, "The innocent will prove their innocence¹."

It was just that Bai Weiwei's situation was a bit difficult to handle.

Liang Shi suddenly became curious, "You and Bai Weiwei, you're really not a couple?"

Zhao Xuning: "..."

After a long while, just when Liang Shi thought Zhao Xuning wouldn't speak, Zhao Xuning shrugged and frankly admitted, "We had some ambiguous moments when we used to play games together."

"Then why didn't you get together?"

Zhao Xuning fell silent again.

After a moment, she smiled bitterly, "I haven't forgotten my ex."

Liang Shi: "..."

Unexpectedly, she was quite the romantic.

But chatting about personal matters made Liang Shi feel that the distance between them had suddenly shortened.

And Zhao Xuning seemed to have a much better attitude toward her, without the distant and disgusted emotions she had when they first met.

The two quietly stayed in the corridor for a while.

Footnotes

¹ **The innocent will prove their innocence (清者自清):** A Chinese idiom meaning that those who are innocent will naturally clear their name through their actions and character, without needing to actively defend themselves.

Chapter 27-15

Suddenly, someone outside said, "You can't go in, Dr. Zhao isn't working today."

"Get out of the way," came a cold female voice.

Zhao Xuning's ears twitched, and she almost instantly recognized the voice of the visitor.

Liang Shi sympathetically smiled bitterly, "Another one looking for you. Do you need me to go out and help you send her away?"

Zhao Xuning put her hands in the pockets of her white coat and turned to walk outside, "This person, you can't send away."

Liang Shi: "..."

She patted Zhao Xuning's shoulder, "Then good luck."

Zhao Xuning's cold eyes swept over Liang Shi's hand, and Liang Shi quickly withdrew it, smiling at her.

Zhao Xuning sighed, "You're in a good mood today."

"I just feel that life is beautiful," Liang Shi said. "So I should live happily."

Zhao Xuning: "..."

As she opened the door, she still teased, "Those words don't sound like Liang Shi at all."

Liang Shi didn't care, "However I am, I'm still Liang Shi."

Zhao Xuning didn't respond further, but had already walked out, responding to the voice outside, "Shen Hui, I'm here."

Whether it was Liang Shi's imagination or not, she felt that when Zhao Xuning called out those two words "Shen Hui," there was a hint of tenderness.

It was completely different from the usually cold Zhao Xuning.

With the mindset of "idle is idle, might as well watch some gossip," Liang Shi also opened the door and walked out.

The VIP ward corridor was very empty, with only Chen Liuying sitting on a bench at the end of the corridor, quite far from where they were.

Zhao Xuning was standing with a tall, thin woman.

Liang Shi could only see her back.

She was wearing a gray wool coat with a very proper cut, her brown long hair reaching her waist, and she was about the same height as Zhao Xuning.

Liang Shi happened to be going back to the ward to see if the two crying people had finished, so she had to pass by them.

As she passed, she just heard Shen Hui say, "I'm returning this to you. Don't leave your things at my place anymore."

Liang Shi: "...?"

Oh ho? Ex-girlfriend?!

Liang Shi couldn't suppress her curiosity and looked back, but unexpectedly met Shen Hui's gaze.

Shen Hui had very beautiful eyes, with light brown pupils, somewhat similar to her own eye color.

Shen Hui had very fair skin, like milk, but she was somewhat too thin.

She seemed to naturally have a heartless face¹.

But Liang Shi also felt she looked very familiar.

She thought for a long time but couldn't remember where she had seen her before.

She could only categorize this feeling as the original owner having seen her before, leaving some memory in this body.

It was just that she didn't remember.

She gave the other person a polite smile, then turned and walked away.

But Shen Hui kept watching her back, feeling inexplicably familiar.

Zhao Xuning also turned to look, and only after Liang Shi entered the ward did she say with slight displeasure, "She's gone now."

Only then did Shen Hui withdraw her gaze.

She looked at the ring box in Zhao Xuning's palm, her voice cool and thin, "Who was that?"

Zhao Xuning's eyes were deep, her brows slightly furrowed. She didn't answer directly, but instead asked, "Do you like her?"

Shen Hui also didn't answer directly, smiling, "I feel some affinity with her."

She always felt she should have seen her somewhere before.

Zhao Xuning said, "She has a wife."

Upon hearing this, Shen Hui looked at her and raised an eyebrow, "When you had a girlfriend, you could still cheat."

"I told you, that was a misunderstanding," Zhao Xuning said. "I didn't do anything."

"Right, it was her who stripped your clothes," Shen Hui smiled mockingly, those eyes so cold they had no warmth. "Alright, Miss Zhao, I still have things to do, I'll leave first."

"Shen Hui," Zhao Xuning said. "Whether you believe it or not, I really didn't do anything to betray you."

Shen Hui didn't even turn back, "Oh."

"At that time I loved you so much..." Zhao Xuning's words stopped halfway, she looked down and smiled bitterly, swallowing all the explanatory words back into her stomach. Looking at Shen Hui's retreating figure, her eyes even showed tears.

Not just at that time.

She still loved her now.

She couldn't help but call out, "Shen Hui, eat more, don't be picky about food."

Shen Hui's steps paused slightly. She turned back, coldly saying, "You really are affectionate to everyone."

Zhao Xuning's voice became heavy, with a hint of reluctance, "And don't lose any more weight."

Shen Hui laughed coldly, "Then I hope Dr. Zhao won't call her ex-girlfriend in the middle of the night because of her current girlfriend's problems."

She looked Zhao Xuning up and down, "That only makes me look down on you."

Zhao Xuning immediately explained, "I'm single."

Shen Hui: "The press release is already out, wasn't that you in those photos? Are you saying that even after hugging, kissing, and maybe even sleeping together, she's still not your girlfriend? I didn't expect Dr. Zhao's standards to be so loose now."

Zhao Xuning: "..."

"I never touched her," Zhao Xuning said. "I just rescued her, that's all."

Shen Hui looked at her coldly, saying casually, "Whatever you say."

After speaking, she left the hospital.

Footnotes

¹ **Heartless face (薄情脸)**: A Chinese expression describing someone who has naturally cold or aloof facial features, giving the impression of being emotionally distant or indifferent.

Chapter 27-16

//

Zhao Xuning walked to the hospital room entrance with a heavy heart, leaning against the wall in a daze.

Meanwhile, inside the room.

Xu Qingzhu had already comforted Bai Weiwei and learned the truth from her, while also helping her condemn Chen Liuying.

At first, Bai Weiwei remained silent, then gripped Xu Qingzhu's hand and said, "I'm going to settle things with her once and for all."

Xu Qingzhu patted her shoulder, "It's okay, you still have me."

She smiled and said, "When love is gone, there are still sisters. I'll always be here."

Bai Weiwei was infected by her smile and also smiled, but still asked in a low voice, "You weren't hurt that night, were you?"

"No," Xu Qingzhu said. "Liang Shi and the others arrived just in time, and my clothes were still on. Thanks to them."

"Yes," Bai Weiwei sighed. "That night was quite desperate."

"It's all in the past. Just be more careful in the future," Xu Qingzhu asked her. "Are you going to continue being an agent?"

This industry was too complex; one wrong step could lead to falling into an abyss.

Bai Weiwei thought for a moment and smiled bitterly with helplessness, "Probably not. The situation has blown up so much that my parents have already seen the news and want me to work at the family company."

"That's good too," Xu Qingzhu said. "I'm also back at the family company now."

The two chatted for a while, and since Bai Weiwei's body hadn't fully recovered, she soon became drowsy. Xu Qingzhu sat beside her, coaxing her to sleep.

After she fell asleep, Liang Shi lowered her voice and said, "She looks so tired."

Xu Qingzhu smoothed out the wrinkles between her brows and gestured to Liang Shi, and the two left the room.

But the moment the door closed, Bai Weiwei opened her eyes.

Her hollow eyes were filled with despair.

Why was Liang Shi able to arrive so timely?

Why did Bamboo's relationship with Liang Shi get better and better after experiencing such things?

Why was she misunderstood as cheating?

She loved Chen Liuying so much.

A tear streamed down Bai Weiwei's face as she despairingly closed her eyes again.

//

Both Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu were in poor spirits when they returned home that evening.

Xu Qingya was still waiting for them at home. As soon as she saw them return, she immediately got up to greet them, "My goodness, I thought you two were going to sleep at the office."

Xu Qingzhu glanced at her, "Can't you tell? We were avoiding you, so we came back late."

"Hey now," Xu Qingya pouted. "You're my real sister."

"Oh." Xu Qingzhu hung up her bag and casually asked, "Did you eat dinner?"

"I did," Xu Qingya said. "By the way, I start school this Sunday."

Xu Qingzhu leaned against the sofa, tiredly pressing her temples, "Do you need us to take you?"

Xu Qingya turned to look at Liang Shi, "Sister Liang, can you take me? In that Porsche."

Xu Qingzhu: "...Vain."

"What's wrong with a teenage girl being a little vain?" Xu Qingya said defiantly despite being in the wrong. "Do I have to become a bookworm like you?"

Xu Qingzhu gave her a cold look.

Xu Qingya wisely didn't continue arguing with Xu Qingzhu. She just greeted Liang Shi and went back to her room.

Seeing that Xu Qingzhu was too tired, Liang Shi walked over and asked if she wanted to go upstairs to take a bath before sleeping. Xu Qingzhu said, "You use the one upstairs. I'll wash downstairs."

Since she was staying in someone else's house, there was no reason to take over their space¹.

Liang Shi didn't stand on ceremony with her, but helped her bring her toiletries down from upstairs.

Liang Shi always bathed quickly. After she finished and came out, she stood upstairs looking down, always worried that with Xu Qingzhu's constitution, she might faint while bathing.

¹ **Taking over their space (鸠占鵲巢):** A Chinese idiom literally meaning "a dove occupying a magpie's nest," referring to someone taking over what rightfully belongs to another person.

Chapter 27-17

Soon after, Xu Qingya came out of her room holding a water cup.

She looked up, "Sister Liang, what are you looking at?"

Liang Shi's face turned slightly red, "Nothing... I'm just looking at the scenery."

Xu Qingya: "?"

She went to the kitchen to pour some water, then noticed her sister coming out of the downstairs bathroom with wet hair and her whole body surrounded by misty water vapor.

She had clearly just finished showering.

She walked over with the cup, "Why are you showering downstairs?"

Xu Qingzhu was using a towel to dry her hair. When she wanted to speak, her throat felt dry, so Xu Qingya thoughtfully handed over the cup.

Xu Qingzhu took a sip of water to moisten her throat before answering, "Liang Shi is showering upstairs."

Xu Qingya: "...It's not like you two can't shower together."

Xu Qingzhu was just taking her second sip from the cup when she heard this and immediately choked, coughing violently.

Xu Qingya patted her back while saying, "Do you really need to react so strongly?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

"You're already married, taking a shower together isn't a big deal, right?" Xu Qingya said. "You could even help each other apply body wash and stuff."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Shut up.

Her ears turned completely red.

But she was also secretly relieved that Liang Shi hadn't heard this, otherwise she would think her sister was too bold.

Then Xu Qingya's next sentence was, "Don't you think so, Sister Liang?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She looked up and directly met another embarrassed face.

The two made eye contact, then simultaneously looked away.

Both socially died¹.

Xu Qingya pouted, "I don't understand you adults. Even after marriage, you're all so shy."

Xu Qingzhu: "What would a kid like you understand? Go back to sleep."

Xu Qingya made a dismissive sound, looked up at Liang Shi, and shrugged indifferently, "You two better not let me find out this is a sham marriage²."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

"What sham marriage?" Xu Qingzhu panicked a bit but still pretended to be calm. "What kind of things are you reading every day?"

Xu Qingya: "Proper things."

She raised an eyebrow at Xu Qingzhu, "Domineering Little Wife Falls for Me³, do you want to read it? I have two more copies."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Please just shut up.

Xu Qingya looked up and asked again, "Sister Liang, do you want to read it?"

Liang Shi: "..."

She stopped reading this kind of novel in high school, okay?

Xu Qingya said with a pretentious air of sophistication, "I have one that's especially suitable for you."

Afraid she would be embarrassed, Liang Shi coughed lightly, "What?"

Xu Qingya: "Tsundere Sweet Wife Falls for Me⁴."

Liang Shi: "..."

Xu Qingzhu gave her sister a pat, "Go back to your room and sleep."

Xu Qingya was still making a last-ditch effort, "Really, Sister Liang, it's really good. You won't regret investing in it⁵."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Footnotes

¹ **Socially died (社死)**: Internet slang meaning to be so embarrassed that one feels like they've died socially; experiencing extreme embarrassment.

² **Sham marriage (形婚)**: A marriage of convenience or fake marriage, often referring to marriages that exist only on paper without real romantic involvement.

³ **Domineering Little Wife Falls for Me (霸道小嬌妻愛上我):** A typical title format for Chinese romance novels, particularly in the "domineering CEO" genre popular in web literature.

⁴ **Tsundere Sweet Wife Falls for Me (傲嬌甜妻愛上我):** Another typical romance novel title. "Tsundere" refers to a character who is initially cold or hostile but gradually shows their warmer side.

⁵ **You won't regret investing in it (入股不虧):** Internet slang originally from stock market terminology, now used colloquially to mean "it's worth your time/money" or "you won't regret it."

Chapter 27-18

//

The next morning, the book "Tsunidere Sweet Wife Falls for Me" appeared on their dining table.

Meanwhile, Xu Qingya was still sleeping in her room.

Xu Qingzhu held the book, pressing her forehead with a headache, "Sorry, this kid always likes to read some improper things."

Liang Shi: "Ah, well..."

"I'll throw it away," Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi quickly stopped her, "Don't. After all, it's something she really likes. If she finds out you threw it away, she'll definitely make a fuss."

Xu Qingzhu: "...You spoil her too much."

"It's okay," Liang Shi smiled. "She's just a kid, actually quite well-behaved."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

So when going to work, Liang Shi took the book along to appease Xu Qingya.

She even flipped through a few pages when bored at work.

It was a yuri¹ novel with quite an interesting setting. She had nothing to do in the magazine department in the morning, so she idly read half of it.

She had nothing to do in the afternoon either, so she simply adapted the first few chapters into a script.

After finishing, Liang Shi realized: she was really idle.

When getting off work that day, Liang Shi heard the system's command: [Hello host, your passive task will expire this Sunday. You can choose to abandon the task before midnight today without penalty, deducting 1 luck point. If overdue and incomplete, 3 misfortune points will be added. Please complete the passive task as soon as possible! PS: The earlier you complete the passive task, the richer the rewards! Another PS: You're the fastest task-completing host Little System has ever seen! Your luck points have now accumulated to 27 points! Please keep up the good work, Little System is always cheering for you!]

The system's voice was that kind of weird mechanical sound, sometimes intermittent because it couldn't break sentences properly.

So it sounded very harsh.

But after so many times, Liang Shi had gotten used to it.

She could even respond to the system, "You're the most nitpicky system I've ever encountered."

...

People are always unconsciously assimilated.

She actually! Started using particle words² too!

//

On Saturday, Father Liang held an auction, followed by a dinner after the auction ended.

Liang Shi didn't know about it initially.

Liang Xinhe called her Friday evening after work to tell her, and specifically instructed her to bring Xu Qingzhu.

After their marriage, Xu Qingzhu had never attended any formal occasions with the original owner.

Only when the original owner wanted to torment Xu Qingzhu would she bring a bunch of fair-weather friends home to make a mess and have Xu Qingzhu clean up.

At other times, she barely paid any attention to Xu Qingzhu.

Liang Shi originally wanted to decline, but Liang Xinhe said meaningfully, "This is a good opportunity to build connections. You don't need it, but doesn't sister-in-law³ need it?"

Liang Shi: "..."

She compromised.

Xu Qingzhu needed it.

Xu Qingzhu was a female Omega who wanted to take her company public.

She couldn't become a stumbling block on Xu Qingzhu's path to success.

So on Saturday, both of them went to the salon for styling and selected two evening gowns.

Liang Shi chose a light blue evening dress with a long skirt that exposed her delicate collarbones, perfectly paired with a silver collarbone chain.

Xu Qingzhu chose a water-green evening dress, similar in style to Liang Shi's, paired with the same collarbone chain.

Both had their hair restyled, making them absolutely captivating to look at.

When Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu came out of the fitting room in their evening gowns, their gazes toward each other were filled with amazement.

The sales assistant was also stunned, and after a long while, sincerely praised them: "You two have simply worn these dresses to their highest level. It's not our dresses that complement you, but you who complement these two dresses. Wearing them, you look like a couple's outfit⁴ - you have such a perfect wife-wife vibe⁵."

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu then went directly to the venue in their gowns.

Footnotes

¹ **Yuri (百合)**: A genre focusing on romantic relationships between women; GL (Girls' Love) in Chinese web literature.

² **Particle words (語氣助詞)**: In Chinese, these are words like "呢" (ne), "啊" (a), "哦" (o) that express tone, emotion, or emphasis at the end of sentences.

³ **Sister-in-law (妹妻)**: Literally "younger sister's wife," a term of address for one's younger sibling's spouse.

⁴ **Couple's outfit (情侶裝)**: Matching or coordinated clothing worn by couples to show their relationship.

⁵ **Wife-wife vibe (妻妻相)**: Internet slang referring to the chemistry or appearance of compatibility between two women, suggesting they look like a married couple.

Chapter 27-19

The afternoon's auction was boring and uninteresting.

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu sat in the back, with people constantly turning around to look at them.

Liang Shi's transformation was too dramatic, and everyone present didn't recognize her at first.

Someone had to remind them, "This seems to be Mr. Liang's third daughter."

Only then did everyone suddenly realize—wasn't this the Third Miss Liang who used to wear heavy makeup all the time and only knew how to cause trouble?

How had she become so beautiful after not seeing her for just a few days?

Did she go to H Country¹ for plastic surgery?

In any case, she was unbelievably beautiful.

And the person beside her was naturally Miss Xu.

According to status, the current Xu family certainly didn't deserve to appear at this kind of banquet, but who told them they had connected with the Liang family?

However, the circle had always been spreading rumors that Third Miss Liang, even after marriage, was still a butterfly who frequently lingered among flowers². How had she suddenly changed her nature and brought her wife to attend the auction?

For a while, everyone was whispering among themselves.

Too many gazes fell on them, and Xu Qingzhu felt somewhat unaccustomed for a moment.

Instead, it was Liang Shi who patted the back of her hand to comfort her, "It's okay, they're just looking because we're beautiful."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She looked over in bewilderment, discovering that Liang Shi had said those words very frankly.

Xu Qingzhu thought she had misheard.

How had she never noticed that Liang Shi was so narcissistic?

But she didn't mind, constantly comforting herself in her heart that she would have to get used to it eventually.

Let others look if they wanted to—it wouldn't reduce her by a piece of flesh.

From beginning to end, she maintained an unsmiling appearance, looking cold and unapproachable.

The auction quickly began. Initially, they auctioned small items, with prices starting from ten thousand.

Liang Shi wasn't very interested in these things.

But Xu Qingzhu kept observing the people present, while also observing the items on stage.

Until a new auction item was brought up—it was a silver bracelet that didn't look very high quality. The auctioneer introduced it as a pure silver bracelet, a family heirloom left by Old Madam Sheng³, donated anonymously.

The Sheng family name hadn't appeared in this circle for a long time.

Everyone knew that the Sheng family had once produced a genius architect named Sheng Qinglin⁴ who was unwilling to inherit the family business, but died young, causing the family business to fall into the hands of Xu Guangyao⁵, who wasn't very good at business, leading to its decline.

So when Sheng family items suddenly appeared, it caused quite a stir.

Could this thing have been donated by the Sheng family daughter?

But the Sheng family daughter wasn't crazy—why would she donate such a precious item?

Everyone looked at each other, discussing among themselves for a moment.

Meanwhile, the auctioneer was already calling out on stage, "This auction item has a starting bid of one hundred thousand yuan."

Someone immediately shouted from below, "One hundred fifty thousand."

Footnotes

¹ **H Country:** Likely refers to South Korea (한국/Hanguk), which is famous for plastic surgery and cosmetic procedures in East Asian culture.

² **Butterfly who lingered among flowers (流連花叢的花蝴蝶):** A Chinese idiom describing someone (usually a woman) who flirts with many people or has multiple romantic relationships.

³ **Old Madam Sheng (盛老太太):** A respectful title for an elderly woman from the Sheng family, indicating her high status within the family hierarchy.

⁴ **Sheng Qinglin (盛清林):** The name suggests someone from the Sheng family. "Qing" (清) means "clear/pure" and "Lin" (林) means "forest."

⁵ **Xu Guangyao (許光耀):** This appears to be Xu Qingzhu's father's name. "Guang" (光) means "light" and "Yao" (耀) means "shine/glory."

Chapter 27-20

Xu Qingzhu looked at the bracelet on stage, her eyes reddening.

She knew who had donated it.

Xu Qingzhu's impression of her maternal grandmother was actually very faint now.

She only remembered that she was a very kind old lady who would often hold her in a rocking chair at sunset, gently swaying back and forth, occasionally telling some old-fashioned stories.

But seeing the old keepsake still made her eyes red.

Liang Shi obviously noticed this too, and asked in a low voice, "Do you want me to help you bid for it?"

The bidding had already reached 250,000.

For silver items, unless they had special significance, this was already a very high price.

The previous items had all sold for no more than 150,000.

But Xu Qingzhu shook her head at Liang Shi. After the 250,000 bid was called for the second time, she raised her paddle, "460,000."

In the end, she won the bracelet for 460,000.

It wasn't because she bid high, but because when people saw her, they hazily remembered that the former Miss Sheng and Old Madam Sheng¹ were both renowned beauties of their time.

And the current Miss Xu was naturally no exception.

She was beautiful to the degree that one glance would be unforgettable.

When the auction ended and Xu Qingzhu received her item, Liang Shi said from the side, "Your arm is quite suitable for wearing silver bracelets, very beautiful."

Xu Qingzhu's fingers caressed the bracelet, her eyes full of attachment. After a moment, she said to Liang Shi, "Give me your hand."

Liang Shi was surprised: "Hm?"

But she still obediently extended her hand.

Xu Qingzhu grabbed her hand, turned it over to show the back, and directly put the bracelet on her arm.

Liang Shi: "?"

"Why are you giving me such a precious thing?" Liang Shi said. "What if I lose it..."

"Would you lose it?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi shook her head: "I suppose not."

"Your arm also looks quite good wearing bracelets," Xu Qingzhu said. "Besides, this should have been yours anyway."

Liang Shi: "Ah?"

"I bought it with the money you gave me," Xu Qingzhu said. "Naturally, the ownership rights belong to you."

Liang Shi: "..."

She suddenly remembered the 450,000 and couldn't help saying, "But I only gave you 450,000, and you bid 460,000 for it."

"That ten thousand..." Xu Qingzhu looked at her, paused, "was your pocket money."

Liang Shi: "..."

She felt somewhat moved for a moment.

Although the style of this bracelet was somewhat old-fashioned, it wasn't ugly at all. It even matched Liang Shi's arm particularly well, looking much better than wearing million-yuan designer pieces.

Liang Shi said helplessly, "How should I thank you for this?"

She had given her a family heirloom.

Xu Qingzhu smiled, her eyes still light and indifferent, "When you get your next paycheck, treat me to dinner."

Liang Shi: "..."

She had a sudden inspiration, "No need to wait for my paycheck. How about tomorrow? I'll treat you to dinner and a movie."

This way she could complete her passive task.

She really was a perfectly ordinary little genius.

Xu Qingzhu looked at her, and she immediately said, "I'll use my pocket money. I saved some from last time."

Her tone carried a hint of little pride, and Xu Qingzhu found it amusing, so she nodded, "Alright."

Liang Shi: "!"

Yes.

The passive task would be completed soon.

Initially, when she learned about these troublesome tasks, Liang Shi thought they were garbage and burdensome.

But doing them up to this point, she actually felt like she was going through life's challenges.

She even detected a bit of fun in it.

This was probably how people could always find joy in suffering?

Liang Shi even smiled helplessly at herself.

Xu Qingzhu asked her, "What are you smiling about?"

Liang Shi lowered her voice and said, "I'm happy."

Xu Qingzhu was about to speak when they heard a sinister, casual voice say, "I wonder what made my baby so happy? I'd like to hear about it too."

Liang Shi felt disgusted just hearing this voice.

She turned around, and sure enough, it was Zhou Yi'an.

Zhou Yi'an's eyes lit up when she saw her, "Baby, you look so beautiful today."

Liang Shi: "..."

Baby your head².

Footnotes

¹ **Old Madam Sheng (盛老夫人)**: A formal, respectful title for the elderly matriarch of the Sheng family, indicating her high status and age.

² **Baby your head (賣你個頭)**: A Chinese expression of dismissal/annoyance, equivalent to saying "Baby my ass" or "Don't call me baby" in English.